



Long Tan Action

This commemorative artwork was painted by Australian war artist Bruce Fletcher in 1970. Some of the details—such as the headlamps on the APCs and the resupply by cargo hook—are embellishments. Supplies were dropped rather than lowered, and headlamps were turned off.

Holding out

Meanwhile, the Australians at Long Tan began to run out of ammunition. At 6:08 p.m., two Australian helicopters dropped fresh supplies. Smith reformed his company into a consolidated defensive position. Shortly afterward, the Viet Cong launched a massed assault, attacking on three sides. A combination of determined resistance and artillery fire held them off until the arrival of the relief force as darkness fell at 7 p.m. This forced the enemy to withdraw, and within 15 minutes all firing had ceased.

The Australians had lost 18 and 24 were wounded. Sweeps of the area the next day showed that at least 245 Viet Cong had been killed (although the number may have been as high as 800). Australian dominance of Phuoc Tuy was not seriously challenged again.